Session 17

2025-07-20

1 - Looting the dead

~12:30, 9 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The party works through the dead alongside the caravan guards while the merchants dig two graves in the road — the bandits to a shared shallow pit, the two fallen guards to their own deeper mound with piled stones against the wolves. The plentiful crossbow bolts scattered around are gathered back into the quivers.
2. The two captains and the lead bandit are stripped first: pooled coin and a scimitar. The strange metal cylinders are claimed by Amidamaru, one broken, one whole, along with a horn of black powder and a bag of small iron pellets.
3. The rest of the bandit dead yield some more coins, one of them foreign, some weapons and two bottles of hard drink. Coin gets divided among the party, and Eguzkilore pockets one of the rum bottles for Nuberroca.
4. Mialee tries to repair the crushed pistol with her magic. She manages to straighten the tube and glue the wood but not re-assemble a mechanism she does not understand. She also rounds a lead ball back to shape, giving Amidamaru one usable round.
5. **Edhelri** waits at the head of the line and the merchants are visibly tired of the wait: an hour is turning into two.

2 - The lodged bullet

1. Nyx focuses on Nuberroca's collarbone wound — it isn't magic, it's a projectile, and something is still lodged inside.
2. Amidamaru wakes the leader of the bandits and presses the intact pistol against his eyes, finger on the trigger, asking how it works. The captain, calm at first, tries to lie — he tells Amidamaru to grip it by the metal part and aim with the wood, the wooden butt sold as the barrel. Amidamaru, an artificer who has spent the better part of an hour on the weapon, calls the bluff and brings the muzzle closer to the captain's head.
3. Pressed on the road ahead, the captain names the Fields of the Dead — an old massive battlefield north of Baldur's Gate. Do not make fire at night, do not call attention: the dead there do not rest as well as they should. Amidamaru's read on the man matches: terrified, straight-answering, telling truth.
4. Asked for the weapons, the leader spurts lies. Amidamaru pulls the trigger, but the pistol is unloaded and nothing happens; the captain breathes back into himself, the pistol is no longer a threat.
5. Nyx steps up at Amidamaru's shoulder with an arrow nocked, and the pressure changes hands. The captain says they were hired months ago by merchants from a city he cannot name, paid in these curious weapons; the powder is for winter fires, he offers — the lie a giveaway of how little he intends to explain, and Amidamaru's own time of study is not enough to reconstruct the loading from combat memory alone. Their camp is west along a bearing he points out, and empty of anything worth taking — they sleep in the woods and only take rooms at taverns when the coin is fresh.
6. Nuberroca crosses to the captain who shot him and asks him plainly *"¿cómo se saca esta bola demoníaca que me has tirado?"* — the man answers honestly: they've dug bullets out a few times, and the men mostly die of fevers in the days after. Nuberroca tells him back, low and level, that if he dies of it the captain dies first — the man goes white.
7. ***[EPIC]*** Nyx pours vodka along the dagger to clean it; Kaelthar leans in and talks her through it, enough to guide her hand but not to steady the cut. Nuberroca drops into a full rage to ride out the pain. Nyx digs, does not sever an artery, and finally levers the pellet out; blood is sheeting out of the shoulder by the time she has it in her palm.
8. Mialee wraps the wound with strips torn from the dead bandits' clothing while a blue glow staunches the bleeding. Kaelthar uses a measure of his healing touch, but the wound itself is still open when they are done.

3 - The prisoners

1. Amidamaru opens the argument to the group: leave the three bound to a tree and let the road settle them. Nuberroca refuses and takes them for himself — properly fed they can pull their weight, and he has already promised the wounded captain a matched death if he tries anything. He walks them to Edhelri and posts them; she will not have three bandits riding on a wagon and says so, and they walk beside, tied.
2. Before the caravan re-forms, Mialee crosses to Edhelri and asks the names of the two guards who fell in the ambush — **Rand** from her own group and **Lews** from Noohar's. She then hands over five gold pieces, for their families alongside the salaries they were owed. The coin passes down the line hand-to-hand between the guards, in a way that tells the party they look after their own.
3. Later on the ride, Mialee presses a separate case with Edhelri: two guards lost, the surviving bandits could be persuaded to fill the gaps. Edhelri warms to the idea on the strength of the pitch, but Nuberroca — pulled into the conversation as the merchant's sergeant — stonewalls: the men wanted to rob them, not join them.
4. Nuberroca settles the argument with a truce: one week bound, and if they are still with the caravan out of troll country they can walk with pay. Mialee accepts — the point in her head was persuading Nuberroca, and she got it.

4 - The forced march

~14:00, 9 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The party lays the dead in the ground and forms up — an hour and a half lost between the interrogation and the burials — and forces the march to make the next camping place before nightfall. Meals are eaten cold on the wagons, dry rations. When the wounded captain begins to fall behind, Nuberroca lifts him onto his own shoulder rather than let him drop.
2. Amidamaru works Munin at height over the road for the afternoon and evening. Among the guards Eguzkilore is now openly welcome for taking full four-hour watches on his elven trance. Meanwhile they find quiet ways to make the prisoners' walk unpleasant — a stumble here, a polearm haft as if by accident there.
3. At camp the wagons wheel into the usual circle; **Sulesdeg** *"the Pole"*, Beyd's bodyguard, comes across without ceremony, sets a jar of beer in front of each of the party members, quietly thanks them, and reminds them the jars are returned in the morning. Mialee hands hers to Nuberroca.
4. Nyx sets a warding rite on **Noohar**'s cart — the perfumes on his wagon make it the sweetest-smelling of the round. The night passes without incident.

5 – Fever

~08:00, 10 Uktar 1489 DR

1. At breakfast Amidamaru sends Munin over to Nuberroca — he does not want the suspected cultists to see him tending the goliath himself — and reads the wound through the owl's eyes. The bandage is soaked, and though a healing spell closes the skin the pus is welling under the seam. The flesh is red and hot, and the fever is coming in.
2. Four hours of road later Nuberroca is sweating hard and staggering; Edhelri, gentle about it, asks him to walk apart from the line in case the fever is catching.
3. The party rides on and passes into the **Fields of the Dead**. Munin brings back the picture of a country of grass and low tumuli, no trees to speak of, and — more troubling — the occasional carcass of a boar or a stag long dead and untouched by carrion birds.
4. Over lunch Amidamaru pours a stronger healing spell into the shoulder — the pain and the redness ease, but the fever holds; magic has closed the wound and the infection is inside the seam. Kaelthar readies the paladin's sense for the undead and holds it prepared for when the need arises.
5. Amidamaru rides forward to the head of the caravan and pulls the guards of the two cultist wagons into conversation. They admit — with more assessment than warmth — that the party carries the fighting, and one of them notes with mild fascination that the blue giant looks in rough shape.
6. Behind him a small commotion on the caravan — a stumble and a landing — and when Amidamaru turns he sees Nuberroca on the road, unconscious under the fever. Delirious, the goliath prays aloud through his teeth: *"Madre Árbol, mi carne está podrida por la sombra, pero mi espíritu no cederá. Enséñame qué raíz debo arrancar para expulsar esta enfermedad"*. **Beyd** rides across from his own wagon and presses a small cup into Nuberroca's mouth: a sweet, warm wine from his homeland, used for the fevers there. It takes some of the pain off, and the goliath is helped into the wagon under a blanket for the last leg of the day.

6 – Lights in the tumuli

~19:30, 10 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The caravan pulls off the road for supper at the day's stopping-place — inside the Fields now, the road serpentines around the mounds and visibility off the shoulder is poor. Nuberroca is fed inside his wagon; the party eats around the fire.
2. Nyx catches a smear of light between two mounds off to the west — nine points, moving low and erratic, sometimes crossing under the ground and out again. She leaves the fire and works out to a rock at half-distance, hidden. Nyx's mental message reaches Amidamaru with the count and confirmation; he calls Munin back onto his shoulder to see through the owl's eyes too.
3. Kaelthar activates the paladin's sense for the undead and moves closer; a moment later his sense flickers on and off — between four and ten undead, moving beneath the earth.
4. Amidamaru calls out to the merchants, asking what the lights are. **Eldkin** answers in their stead — a caravan guard who has run this route many times — and admits the fault: distracted by the bandits and Nuberroca's collapse, the caravan forgot to keep fires down. Her stories: few travellers survive the lights, and none if they are already noticed.
5. Amidamaru turns himself invisible and walks west past Nyx, dropping a small orb of fire into a stand of dead branches at range — two of the nine lights peel out of formation and drift toward the burn. Four pebbles lit by artificer's magic and thrown further west draw off two more — four wisps drawn off in all, five left to fight.
6. Kaelthar puts a ward against the wicked on himself as a precaution, standing at the end of the party's line — the last thing he sees on the way in is a wisp materialising at his own side.
7. ***[EPIC]*** A crack of light against Kaelthar's flank drops him to one knee, his teeth close on his own scream and it comes out as a bellow. The other lights, all of them, wheel to the noise. Combat is on.

7 - The will-o-wisps

1. Nyx puts an arrow through the closest wisp at long range — the shaft passes through and drops to the ground but the light flickers; they're solid enough, just hard to hurt. Mialee mirrors the shot at a second and marks a hit — Echo, her bat familiar, can use its echolocation to find the invisible ones.
2. Amidamaru drops his shield in the dirt, hums his wizard's war-song to steady the blade, and closes with the rapier — a thunder-charm left ringing on the edge for any wisp that moves once the strike lands.
3. Kaelthar, surrounded and unable to see his attackers, pulls out of the ring with careful footing, spends his healing touch to close his own wounds, and falls back as far as his feet allow. The wisps' pattern reads: appear at the shoulder, strike, blink out. Each landed hit cracks hard with electricity; each miss unspools into the earth. All of them concentrate on Kaelthar — his first scream told them where the living were.
4. Nuberroca — watching from the wagon — remembers older wars: his tribe fought these heralds of the undead armies before, and the shamans used things that emitted light to end them, sometimes blessing the warriors' weapons for more damage. He pours holy water along the edge of his halberd, saved for a real cut. Nyx and Eguzkilore hold their arrows for the moment a wisp materialises, striking as it appears, and Eguzkilore steadies his aim, each shot a little surer. Mialee stays hidden, striking from the shadows.
5. Kaelthar goes down on a critical hit — one strike does it. The wisps, sensing the unconscious body, gather over him to feed. Amidamaru closes on the fallen paladin and pours a healing spell into him, hauling him back to his feet. Nuberroca lays a warband's vigour on Amidamaru so the mage can hold his ground at Kaelthar's shoulder.
6. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca lines the halberd against a wisp harrying Kaelthar and swings; the strike lands, one drop of holy water dripping down the shaft finds the wisp, and it moans out — a low keening like a soul in torment. A later swing puts the water more squarely, and this second wisp shrieks in pain, the light of it flaring before dimming. Nuberroca has found the weapon.
7. Kaelthar drops again — a glancing hit finding him barely healed. Nuberroca reaches him with the crook of the halberd, drags him back into range, and Amidamaru's second healing spell goes into the paladin as he passes.
8. Kaelthar drops a third time under another critical strike from an invisible wisp — Amidamaru has nothing left to cast. Mialee, hidden and reading the field through Echo, uses an unseen hand to feed one of her potions into the paladin's mouth; Kaelthar comes back to consciousness on the ground. Nuberroca lays a warband's vigour on him this time for extra vitality, and a red glow comes across his wounds, partially closing them.
9. Amidamaru is knocked flat by a critical strike from an invisible wisp.
10. ***[EPIC]*** As the wisp turns to feed on the tortle's body, Munin dives from above and takes the blast that would have killed him — the owl throws itself between the wisp and its master and dissolves under the light. A moment later, Nuberroca uses one of Amidamaru's own healing potions to bring him back.
11. The last wisps drop in short succession. Mialee's sneak-strike from the shadows catches one and its light begins to dim; Nyx sinks the last of her Dread Ambusher psychic bite into an arrow, and the final wisp winks out with a moan across the tumuli. Eguzkilore lifts a follow-up shot on the final wisp but the target is already dead. The party stands in the silent dark, most of them wounded and one — Kaelthar — unconscious on the ground again, stabilised only by Nuberroca's healer's hands.

8 - After the wisps

1. Nuberroca lifts Kaelthar onto his shoulder and carries him back into the light of the wagons. The guards close on the party with torches; Amidamaru waves them back and asks them to douse the light — don't attract any more of them — the party can see in the dark well enough to bring Kaelthar in.
2. Nuberroca has faced these things before with his tribe, and he can now tell the others: the lights feed on the unconscious. That is why they crowded around Kaelthar; that is why Munin's death bought Amidamaru his life — the familiar would have interposed itself.
3. By the fire that night the ordeal settles into them — the wisps' cold light burned into memory, the appear-strike-blink cadence learned in bone and hand. Footwork sharpens, strikes fall cleaner, an enemy's next move comes faster in the read. What the tumuli tried to take from them, they carry out the other side as strength.